



Middle-muddle: From No. 3 to No. 8, Samson's unsettled slots mirrored the confusion in India's batting order. ^{AP}

Cup. While flexibility is a fail-safe in times of crisis, it has its pitfalls when it becomes the norm.

There are still some openings in this T20I team. Gill had an underwhelming tournament with the bat, and Yashasvi Jaiswal will be breathing down his Test skipper's neck soon. Samson has appeared scratchy in the middle overs, and if his power-hitting ability is not optimally used in the PowerPlay, Jitesh Sharma, who warmed the bench throughout the competition, is a promising prospect as a lower-order finisher.

India's predilection for batting depth in recent years across formats has come at the cost of a specialist bowler. An all-rounder has been

slotted in at No. 8 in 13 out of the 17 games where India's batting has been stretched that far since the start of 2024.

With the unimpeachable Jasprit Bumrah and the menacing spin duo of Kuldeep Yadav and Varun Chakaravathy being automatic picks, India's highest wicket-taker in T20Is, Arshdeep Singh, had to sit out for five matches at the Asia Cup. The inclusion of Hardik Pandya, Dube and Axar in the top eight meant that India still had at least six viable bowling options, but that strategy is fraught with risk, particularly on flatter surfaces.

Hardik took on the mantle of the second seamer, while Dube stepped into his breach in the all-important final and even took the new ball. Dube, admittedly, has come a long way from just being a dabbly-dobbly slow-medium seam option. He bent his back more during the Asia Cup,

consistently clocked in the mid-130s [kmph], and delivered two crucial performances with the ball against Pakistan, including in the summit clash.

Bumrah's burden

However, the punt on Dube's bowling could be hazardous against more attacking batting. Moreover, if India employs three of Bumrah's overs in the PowerPlay, like it did in four of the five matches he played in the Asia Cup, the absence of a second specialist seamer could hurt the team at the death. Hardik and Dube were India's most profligate bowlers in the last five overs during the Asia Cup, conceding 12 and 13.50 runs an over, respectively. In dewy conditions, the spinners are also risky options in the late overs. The team needs more flexibility and depth on the bowling front.

As the margin of error reduces on batting-friendly pitches back home,